



Bridging the Divide

DELHI For the strained saffron camp, it could be a bridge over troubled waters. After two years of acrimony, VHP and BJP leaders shared a common platform for the first time along with RSS to make a joint demand at a huge rally in Delhi on December 30—that the

proposed Ram Sethu project near Rameswaram in Tamil Nadu be scrapped. On the dais was BJP chief Rajnath Singh along with RSS chief K. Sudarshan and VHP leaders Praveen Togadia and Ashok Singhal. The Supreme Court is slated to hear

RALLYING POINT: VHP and BJP unite on Ram Sethu the Government's plans for the Sethusamudram project at a hearing on January 16.

BJP plans to raise the Ram Sethu issue in the next few assembly elections, just as it did during the Gujarat polls. At a meeting of its core group in Delhi recently, the party decided to go ahead with the Gujarat model of

combining Hindutva with the development plank.

RSS had an important role to play in the coming together of BJP and VHP as it pressured both the outfits to put up a united front. The VHP leadership had lambasted L.K. Advani for his comments on Jinnah in 2005 while on a visit to Pakistan while Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi was attacked for supporting Advani and also for his style of functioning. VHP has also been upset with BJP for failing to build the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya while in power. It campaigned against Modi in Gujarat. Both Modi and Advani were noticeably absent from the show.

On the eve of the rally, Singhal ducked questions on Modi and answered only those on the Ram Sethu. Given all this, the coming together was the first clear signs of a thaw in the feuding parivar. *by Priya Sahgal*

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Their best efforts to defeat Narendra Modi having coming to nought, the secular brigade is busy trying to prove that BJP got less votes than its combined opponents. But isn't that mostly the case in multi-cornered contests?

VOICES

“The Congress and its pseudo-secular supporters sought to convert Gujarat into some kind of national referendum on communalism versus secularism.”

L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition

“I have seen statements of the Union Minister from Bihar (Lalu Prasad Yadav) that the Centre is giving sacks containing money, but I have not received even one.”

Nitish Kumar, Bihar chief minister

“Budgets don't decide elections. Your capacity to deliver what you have promised does. Budgets only raise the expectations and support them through outlays.”

P. Chidambaram, finance minister

“There is no law and certainly no order in my country. The country is paying a heavy price for the bone-headed decisions of one man—Pervez Musharraf.”

Nawaz Sharif, former Pakistan prime minister

“The only thing I am worried about is that we might lose the human element in the game of tennis if we use too much of technology.”

Vijay Amritraj, former tennis player